

Developing Soft Skills and Personality



Professor T. Ravichandran

Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT Kanpur

Week 4
Module 1
Lecture 19

Communication

n

Significance of
Listening



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Breaking Bad Habits

Stop the way you started it—in tiny bits.
Reduce the frequency; increase the gap.
Replacing a bad habit with a good habit

Developing Good Habits

Practice good habits that will free your brain and mind such as:

1. Not leaving any task uncompleted.
2. Unfinished task will hang heavy in your brain causing you less space for focussing and concentrating on new activities.
3. Avoid becoming serial-addicts.

Good Habits and Success are inseparable

Good habits make you indispensable and irreplaceable

Some habits of highly successful people worth inculcating in you:

1. Be extremely hard working
2. Do the extra work with a smile, even if you don't get paid.
3. Never look at your watch and work.

Work till you complete, so that your mind stays calm and you can sleep peacefully each night.

5. Focus on the most important goal.
6. Never spend more time on something that can be completely avoided!
7. Concentrate 100%, you will finish it faster than the rest!



Communication

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Comprehension
Skills





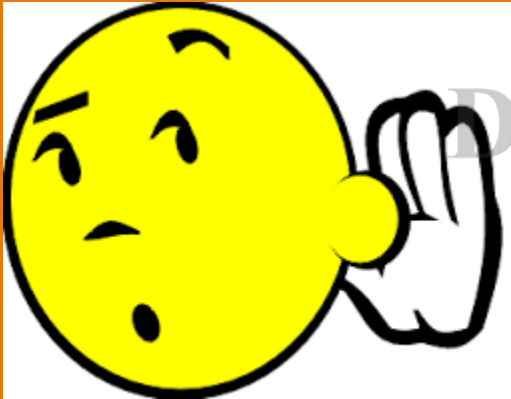
Communication Skills are Integrated



- Both listening and speaking are top skills for winning through GDs and Job Interviews.
- The more one reads, the more one knows
- The more one writes, the more one reflects
- The more one listens, the more one learns!
- The more one listens, and the more one speaks, the more one communicates!
- The more one communicates, the more successful one becomes!



Listening



Listening is an integral part of communication, though much ignored!

Communication and human relationships go hand in hand.

Positive relationships can develop only on the degree and intensity of communication.

The more intense a relationship, the more deep communication develops!



Misconceptions About Communication

- **Speaking is Communication**

**Good Speaking is Good
Communication**

**Talkative people communicate
better than calm and silent people**

**To be a good speaker, you don't
have to be a listener**

Misconceptions About Listening

- *Only intelligent people can listen.*
- **Fact:** Active listening is a cultivated behavior.
- *Speaking is a more important than listening.*
- **Fact:** Both are equally important in effective communication.
- *Speaking consumes energy, not listening.*
- **Fact:** Active listeners spend as much energy as a speaker/jogger.
- *Listening is an unconscious process.*
- **Fact:** Listening is an active mental process; hearing is an involuntary act.
- *Speakers can make their audience listen to them 100 per cent.*
- **Fact:** Speakers cannot make their audience really listen.



Listening Versus Hearing



- Hearing is a Physical activity
- (horn sound, fan sound, birds chirping, etc)
- Involves just hearing
- Listening is a mental activity
- Apart from just hearing, it involves Reception, Selection, Organization, Assimilation, Interpretation, Evaluation and Response.



The First Step in Becoming a Good Listener: Keep the Mind Open!

*“The mind is like a
parachute—
it functions only when
it is open!”*



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Students at the University of California were asked by Mr Agnew of the department of Medical History for their reaction to the following :

"The father has syphilis, the mother tuberculosis. They have had four children—the first blind, the second died, the third was deaf and dumb, the fourth had tuberculosis. The mother is pregnant with her fifth child. The parents are willing to have an abortion. You have to make the decision."

*Most of the students voted in favour of abortion.
Mr Agnew's comment to them:*

**“Congratulations!
You have just murdered Beethoven!”**

*The deaf musical composer and a child
prodigy
who gave his first public performance as a
pianist when he was eight years old!*



The Lesson?

Listen without Prejudice!

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Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT Kanpur

Week 4
Module 2
Lecture 20

Communication

Active Listening



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Looked at listening as an integral part of communication.

Cleared some misconceptions about listening.

Like: To be a good speaker, you don't have to be a listener.

Only speaking consumes energy, not listening.

Difference between hearing and listening.

Hearing is physical, while listening is a mental activity that involves Reception, Selection, Organization, Assimilation, Interpretation, Evaluation and Response.

The first step to become a good listener is to keep one's mind open and free from any prejudice!

Effective Communication



Research indicates that about 60% of listening is involved in Effective Communication.

Only 25% of our listening capacity is used by us.

People don't remember 50% of what they heard within a gap of 8 hours!

Good communication is good listening

One of the major skills in effective communication is the ability to listen well.

- *Listening is the “receiving” part of communication.
- *It is receiving information through your ears and eyes.
- *Good listening is an active, integrated communication skill that demands energy and know-how.
- *It is purposeful, powerful and productive.



A Good Communicator



A good communicator is essentially a good listener. She modulates various verbal/non-verbal symbols she displays depending on the feedback she gathers through simultaneous listening. She not only pays attention to the other person's words but also to his tone and facial expressions and body language.

What is Active Listening?



- Active Listening is whole body listening!
- The person is full of eyes and ears!
- Eyes are focussed on the person talking; and look for body language to correlate with verbal meaning.
- Ears listen carefully
- Brain is receptive and reflects on what is being said
- Mouth is shut
- Hands and feet are still
- Heart feels compassionate
- The whole body is naturally inclined toward the speaker to show interest and empathy.
- The speaker gets a feeling that she is given a careful, thoughtful attention and consideration!

How to Become an Active Listener?



- Be courteous and considerate; treat the speaker like a favourite guest at home!
- Pay full attention: Concentrate and eliminate all distractions (environmental—your phone)
- Don't interrupt
- Note down important points
- Reflect Back: rephrase/restate in your own words, ensuring you have correctly understood, following closely
- Minimise self-talk
- Stay Focused
- Keep asking questions

How to Become an Active Listener?



- Never laugh or give a condescending or sarcastic smile!
- Encourage: nod, smile, lean forward, look into the eyes of the speaker, pat, hug
That's good; sounds good; Damn interesting!
- Acknowledge efforts:
How did you manage it? Wow. How could you do that?
That was a wonderful idea! That was a spending job!
Great work! You are a genius to have done it!
- Use Silence: Silence is effective in making the customer open up; Use comforting calmness; you are calm but warm in your gesture (not silent but cold!)

How to Become an Active Listener?

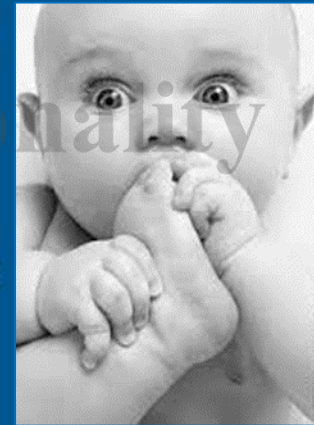


- Summarizing briefly helps you to show your concern and encourages the other person to continue.
- Seek clarifications: When you don't understand what the other person is saying. Feel free to ask:
"What do you mean to say?", "Could you please make this point clear to me?" "I am sorry, I am not able to follow from the point when you said . . . "
- Conclude by thanking the speaker and showing your appreciation; *Nice talking to you; wonderful listening to you! I greatly appreciate the time you gave me!*
- Always, make the speaker leave with a good feeling!
- Leave the dejected one with some hope!

**Speak
Less!**

**Listen
More!**

When you talk,
you are only
repeating what
you already know.
But if you listen,
you may learn
something new.



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Week 4
Module 3
Lecture 21

Communication

Barriers to Active
Listening



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Good Communication is Good Listening.
Good listening is an active, integrated communication skill that demands energy and know-how.

It is purposeful, powerful and productive.

Active Listening: Whole body listening.

Tips for becoming an active listener:

Be courteous and considerate, Don't interrupt
Note down important points, Minimise self-talk
Stay Focused, Encourage, Acknowledge efforts,
Summarise,
Seek Clarifications, Use Silence,
Conclude with a good feeling.

Importance of Active Listening

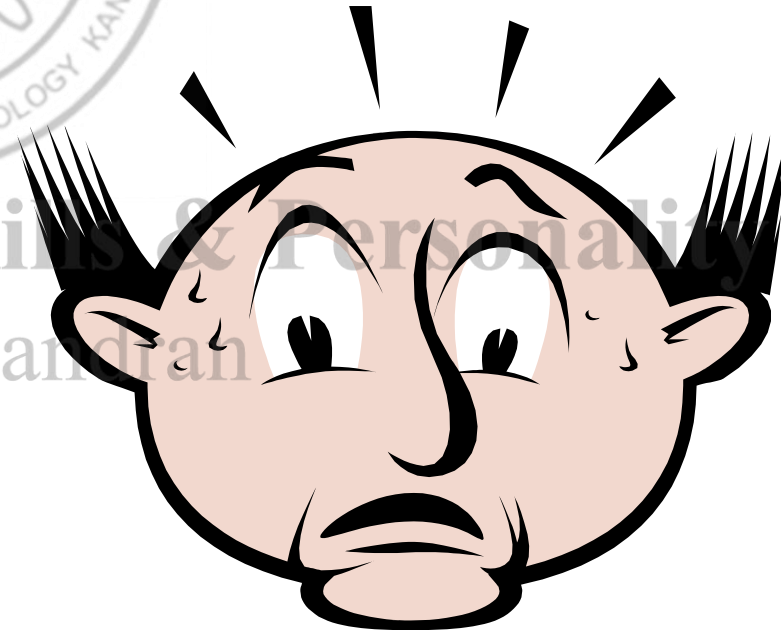
- Knowledge is power; knowing clearly saves lots of time, and saves things from damage.
- Active Listening is the key in successful personal and professional relationships.
- Mind you, it's the quality of your relationships that determines the level of your success!
- AL has a great impact on your job effectiveness.
- It will help you to avoid miscommunication and conflicts.
- Increases productivity
- Improves persuasive and negotiation skills.

Barriers to Active Listening

- Physical Barriers: Outside noise, inside chats, poor acoustics, uncomfortable environment, message overload
- People-Related Barriers:
- Physiological : health conditions, extreme heat or cold, speaker's incoherence or manner of talking
- Psychological: Antipathy for the speaker; preconceived notions, fixed mind-set, cognitive dissonance, personal stress/anxiety, impatience, intolerance.

Barriers to Active Listening

- **Inadequate language Base**
 - **Insufficient technical vocabulary**
 - **Combined with fear or shyness to seek clarifications**



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Barriers to Active Listening

- **Partial Listening**
Distracted with objects on the computer when talking over the phone
- Reading something during a conversation



Disinterestedness



- **Lack of interest in the subject**
- **Paying attention to other subjects**
- **Students recall cricket score better than data shown on an educational video**



Prejudging the Speaker/the Speech

- Forming conclusion about the speech just by looking at the speaker's dress, appearance, posture, etc
- Gender & colour preferences
- Status and Stereotypes affecting critical thinking

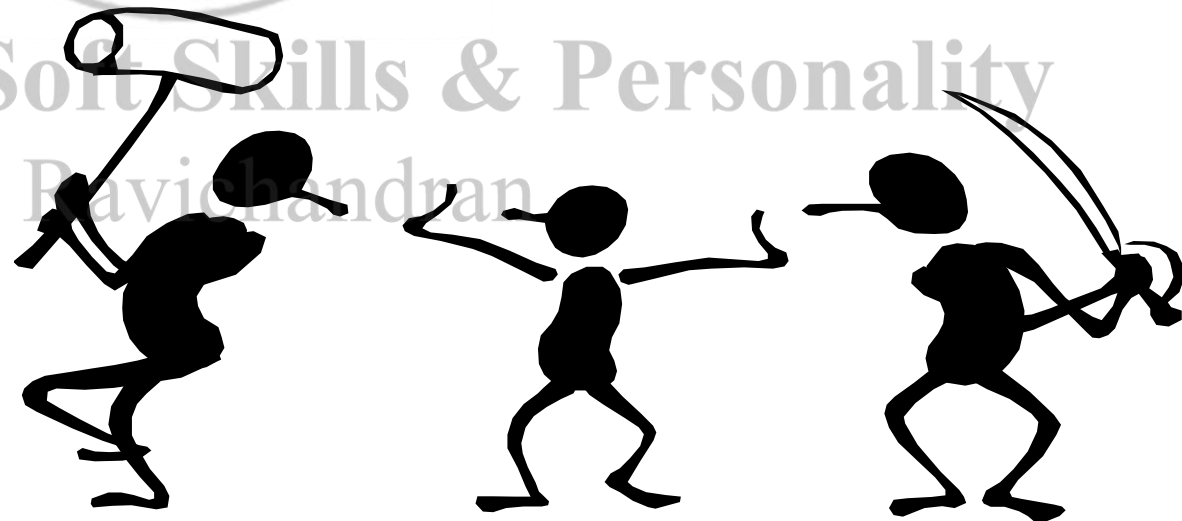


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Negativity towards the Speaker

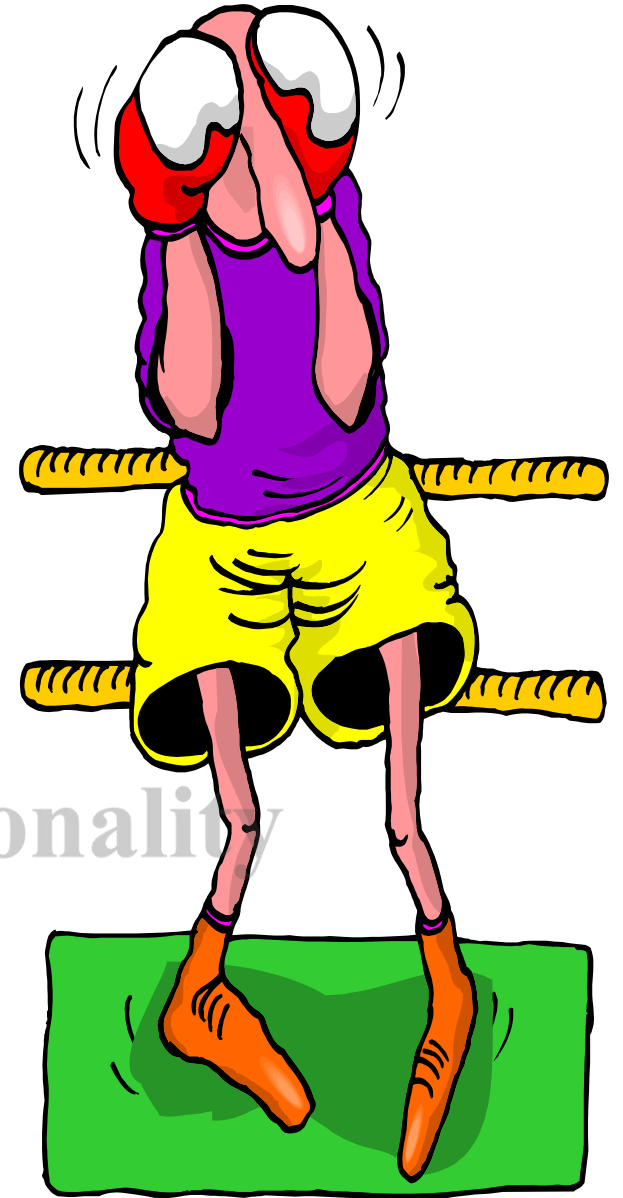
- Underestimating the speaker's capabilities
- Showing animosity
- Disapproving the speaker's view points
- Ending up in constructing distorted message

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Diffidence

- Suffers from a defeatist attitude
- Undermines self-capabilities for fully understanding the subject
- Students and conference participants suffer from this

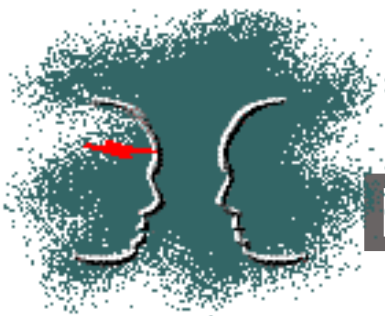


Over-enthusiasm/Intolerance

- Overenthusiastic to supply gaps in the speaker's ideas
- Intolerant to wait till the end of the speech
- Advances questions and interferes quickly
- Anxious to wind up the communication process

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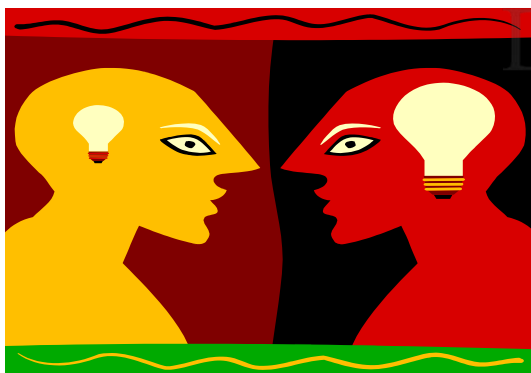




Deep-rooted Beliefs



- **Closed minds due to deep-rooted beliefs and convictions**
- **Leads to superficial listening**
- **Often causes disagreement with the speaker's stance and view point**
- **Can also cause positive bias and influence one's ability to judge**



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Avoid positive bias/influence

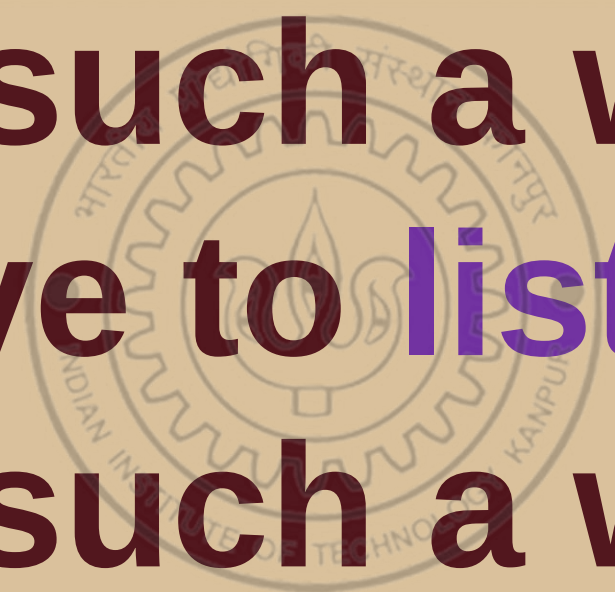
Evaluate the Message:

“Our leader had an unhappy Childhood and little formal education. His father bitterly opposed his ambition to become an artist. Through self-education, he became the author of a book that became a national best seller. Obstacles do not discourage him. When others say, “It’s impossible,” he hurdles each barrier as it comes. He has built an active youth movement of selected young people. He is known throughout the world for his dynamic speeches. His closest associates say of him, “He accomplishes incredible deeds out of the passion of his will in order to create the kind of government he believes in.”

The famous personality is . . .

Adolf Hitler!





Speak in such a way that
others love to **listen** to you.
Listen in such a way that
others love to **speak** to you.

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Developing Soft Skills and Personality



Professor T. Ravichandran
Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT Kanpur

Week 4
Module 4
Lecture 22

Telephone Communication

**Basic Telephone
Skills**



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Importance of Active Listening:

Successful personal & professional relationships, gaining knowledge, job effectiveness, productivity, persuasive and negotiation skills

Barriers to Active Listening: Physical Barriers:

People-Related Barriers: Physiological, Psychological.

Inadequate language base, partial listening, disinterestedness, prejudging, hatred/love for the speaker, diffidence, over-enthusiasm, intolerance, deep-rooted beliefs, positive bias/influence.

Why do you call someone on phone?

Feel bored, just to pass time

Curiosity: Find out what some one is doing

Insecurity: nagging, checking, verifying

Passing information

Sharing good news

Informing about events, appointments

Giving bad news

Discussing ideas

Office, routine business matter

Call for help (security, police)

Call for service (booking tickets, ordering food items)



Telephone Skills



The calls you make, and the way you make them, tells who you are!

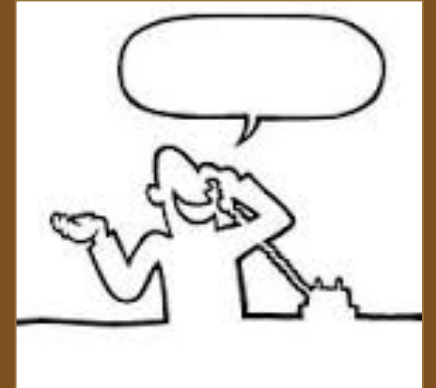
Whom do you avoid on phone? Why?

Loaner?
Enemy?
Neighbour?
Police?
Investigation officer?
Boss?
Wife?
Relative?
Colleague?
Vendor?
Client?
Customer?



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Telephone Skills



The calls you avoid, and the way you avoid them, determines who you are!

Whom do you want to talk to on phone?

Classmate?

Friend?

Lover?

Teacher?

Employer?

Doctor?

A Mentor?

Any Well-Wisher?

An Inspirer?

A Patient?

A Student who needs your help?

Astrologer?

Stranger?



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Telephone Skills



The people you want to talk, and the way you talk to them, tells who you are!

Why phone calls are important? Paradoxical Reasons!

They connect us to people.

Make the human communication warm and alive.

They can also disconnect people;
leaving them cold and uncared for.

While there are some who hate calling some people,
there are others who love to get calls from them!

A phone call could have avoided many suicides
(Albert Camus's *The Fall*)

Not making a call could have made many
live happy lives!

Hence, it is important to use phone calls
wisely and effectively!



Telephone Skills



Phone calls are important aspect of human communication: You can make or mar it!

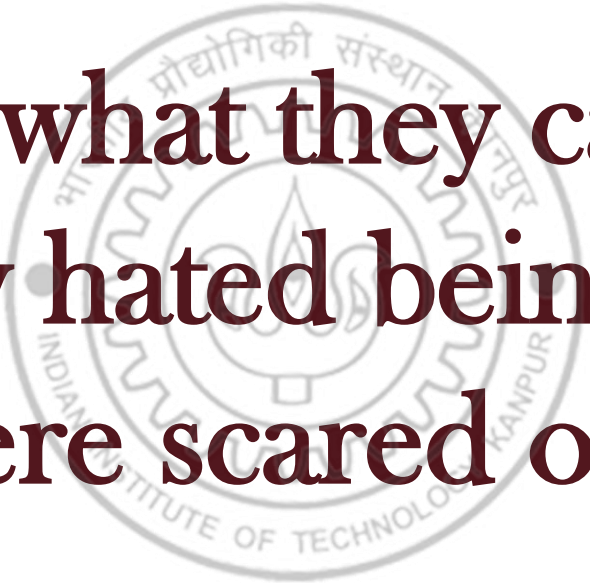


Basic Telephone Skills



- Different from oral: person to person
- If not prepared, ask the person to call again
- Keep a pen and paper: Don't miss important point , number
- Right handed, place phone on left side; use right side for notes.
- Smile, your voice will be different when you do it!
- Be patient
- Time Keep on eye on it; don't rush
- Make the other person speak; don't interrupt
- Never lose your temper
- Don't eat or chew or munch
- Stop reading, typing
- Verbal encouragement:

I see, tell me more, go on, would you like to talk about it



**“People used what they called a telephone
because they hated being close together
and they were scared of being alone.”**

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**Dr. T. Ravi Prakash
Chuck Palahniuk**

Developing Soft Skills and Personality



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Week 4
Module 5
Lecture 23

Telephone Communication

Advanced Telephone
Skills



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Various aspects of telephone communication

The calls you make, and the way you make them, tells who you are!

The calls you avoid, and the way you avoid them, determines who you are!

The people you want to talk, and the way you talk to them, tells who you are!

Phone calls are important aspect of human communication:

You can make or mar it!

Different from oral: face to face communication

Keep a pen and paper: Don't miss important point, number

Smile, your voice will be different when you do it!

Be patient; don't rush

Make the other person speak; don't interrupt

Never lose your temper

Don't eat or chew or munch

Stop reading, typing

Verbal encouragement:

I see, tell me more, go on . . .

Interesting Features of Telephone Communication

**Most commonly used;
and most commonly misused form of communication!
Often the receiver's response is taken for granted.**

**Mostly for the reason that
both the speakers cannot see each other.**

**This is challenging because
people presume so many things .
A simple example: Let's meet at 7 tomorrow.
Where? In the park, during my walk.**

**Effectiveness needs
clarity in communication
and active listening.**



**Advanced
Telephone
Skills**



Some Tips for Developing Advanced Skills

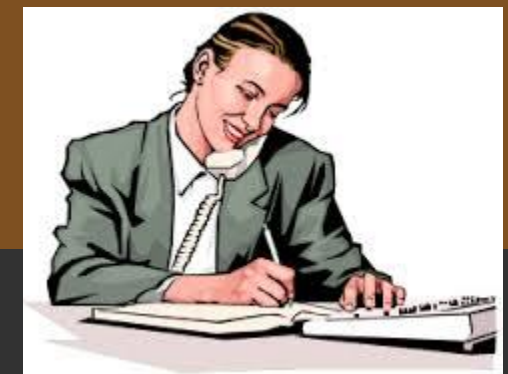
**Enunciate Clearly: Examples: “Lab staff”
“10 Frogs” (medium size!)
Let your voice radiate warmth, respect,
helpfulness.**

**If you represent a company, do not begin
with “Hello”. Start with the name of the
company, use polite greetings (Good
Morning), add your name and offer to help.**

**Example: “Sterling Services. Good Morning.
This is Ronita. How may I help you?”**



**Advanced
Telephone
Skills**





Advanced Telephone Skills



If you are in a key position to deal with many callers, and if you keep some simultaneous callers on hold, first ask for permission:

May I keep you on hold for a moment ma'm?

Will you please wait for a minute, Sir?

when you get back, apologise:

I apologise for keeping you on hold!

Sorry to have kept you on waiting!

Or, Say Thanks:

Thank you for holding!

Thank you for your patience!

Say it with a Smile—

The receiver can actually feel it!





Advanced Telephone Skills

Organise Yourself

Prepare yourself for the call (mentally, emotionally, physically)

Keep mental/written notes ready; it saves time

(human tendency to forget the most important and call again!)

Organise Your Desk

Keep your desk clean. Don't pile things on phone!

Keep the notepad and pen near the phone.

Know your phone; practice & master the equipment

Use speaker; but avoid for privacy

When you make the call

Check the number before dialling

Introduce yourself + polite greetings

Be clear and concise.

Say the right thing at the right time & end aptly.



Advanced Telephone Skills

While Ending

Appreciate: That would be great! It was nice talking to you!

Give Hope: I look forward to your call!

I hope to see you in the party!

Say Bye: Bye, see you soon! Have a nice day!

When the receiver refuses to end!

Politely Say that you have a meeting, class, appointment

When you receive a call on somebody's behalf

Note the details of the call, name of the person, date and time

Purpose of the call, what action needs to be taken, when?

Give such details if you leave a message in an answering machine.



Advanced Telephone Skills

Use a Format

Telephone Notes

Date _____ Time _____

Message for _____

From _____

Message _____

Contact Number _____



Advanced Telephone Skills



Challenges!



Delivering Unpleasant News

Don't beat around the bush! Get straight to the point

State the reason, provide alternative solution

***SAY SORRY:** I am afraid . . . I do apologise . . .*

***IMPORTANT:** You should earn the other's respect!*

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The logo of the Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur is visible in the background. It is a circular emblem with a gear-like outer border. Inside the circle, there is a central figure, possibly a lamp or a traditional symbol. The text "INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY KANPUR" is written in English around the bottom half of the circle, and the Hindi equivalent "भारतीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान कानपुर" is written along the top half.

**“No one loves the messenger
who brings bad news.”**

— Sophocles

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Week 4
Module 6
Lecture 24

Telephone Communication

Essential Telephone Skills



Highlights

Highlights of the Last Lecture



Advanced Telephone Skills

Effectiveness needs clarity in communication and active listening.

Enunciate Clearly: Frogs or Frocks; Lab staff or Lap tops?

Steps involved in holding simultaneous calls

Organizing yourself; organising the desk, knowing your equipment

Norms for making phone calls properly

Ending a call

Noting important information by using a format

Facing challenges like delivering bad news.

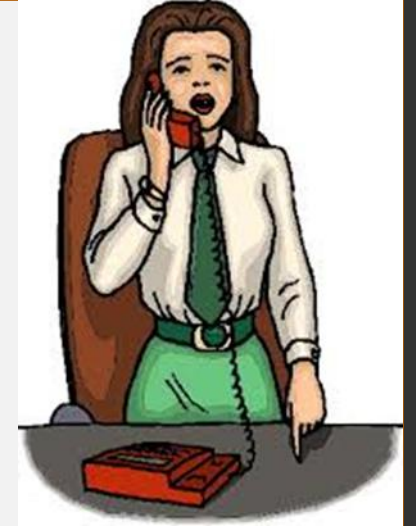
IMPORTANT: You should earn the other's respect!



Essential Telephone Skills

More Challenges!

Handling Difficult Callers!



Be diplomatic. Give facts. Help to resolve problems.

Offer alternative solutions.

SAY: PLEASE understand ***SORRY*** for the mistake

THANK YOU for your understanding

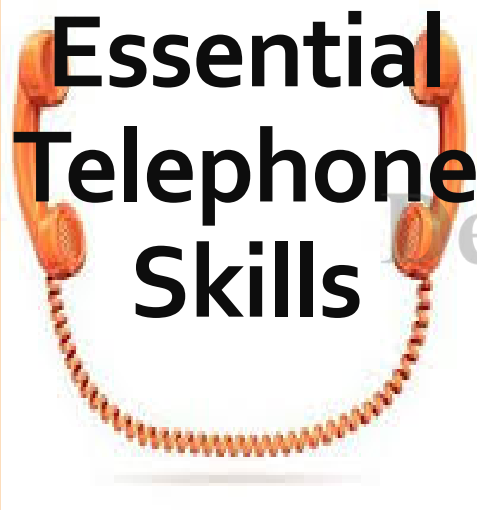
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Dealing with Anger!



Essential Telephone Skills



- ✓ Be cool and calm throughout
- ✓ Use comforting silence & understanding pauses
- ✓ Offer help in whatever manner possible
- ✓ Never raise your voice, even if provoked
- ✓ Apologize for any inconvenience caused
- ✓ Identify the problem
- ✓ Offer possible solution
- ✓ Give compensation
- ✓ In case of abusive expressions, don't get hurt!
- ✓ Act Professionally and Proactively
- ✓ Empathise with the caller
- ✓ Get back with more help and better solutions
- ✓ Promise to call back and follow-up
- ✓ Keep the promise!





Essential Telephone Skills



Manage Your Voice

Your voice can reveal whether you are Sad, sick, tired, frustrated, angry, annoyed, bored, disinterested, stressed, impatient OR Happy, helpful, smiling, cheerful, supportive, careful, empathetic, considerate, friendly.

*Many people don't know they have loud voices!
Many are unaware that their voices are feeble!*

Dr. T. R. Raghavachandran
You will gain confidence on practice

Record your voice and listen to it

*Make yourself comfortable with your voice
(Saying Sorry, Thank you, Welcome)*



Essential Telephone Skills

Be an Active Listener

*Show your involvement by listening sounds which substitute nods: **hmm, okay, I see...***

Be Cheerful

Feel Good, Sound Good and make the receiver feel Good!

Know Your Caller

Try to figure out details of your caller: age, mood, health condition, designation

Use appropriate title for addressing the caller

Replace Fear with Confidence

Use initial fear to energise and stay focussed

Gain confidence by repeating what you fear



Essential Telephone Skills

Be Polite

Know the difference between May I & Can I; Will you please/Can you please

Use

Could you? Would you?

Please, Sorry, Thank you, Welcome

Avoid Jargons

Avoid technical words, words known to small groups, difficult words

Anticipate Problems

Give contingency to technical snags, delays, misunderstandings, flaring up of emotion



Remember:

**Each call is an opportunity
to enhance your personality
and the image of your
organisation!**

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Remember:

**You should be the person
any body wants to talk to;
Not the one everybody wants
to AVOID!**

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“For me, there is no day or night for music. I often work through the night -- without phone calls disturbing me.”

A. R. Rahman

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